

Business, Government, and Society

Instructor: Professor Tarek Ghani

April 2 – 5, 2025

The Brookings Institution
Washington, D.C.

This 4-day immersion program in Washington D.C. provides executives the opportunity to engage with policymakers and witness how policy is formulated. Meeting with scholars from think tanks, such as the Brookings Institution, provides insight into the culture, climate, and decision-making within U.S. institutions. The knowledge accrued during this program enables business leaders to establish relationships that will help them advance their national and global goals.

For over 100 years, the Brookings Institution has been at the forefront of national policy debates. Brookings is consistently ranked as the most influential, most quoted, and most trusted think tank in the world. WashU at Brookings is uniquely positioned to maximize this reputation by engaging renowned policy experts, senior ranking officials, and other key decision-makers to provide students with rich and nuanced knowledge of the policy process.

Brookings scholars and other experts will provide new insights into domestic and global dynamics. Content covered in this residential program is essential for formulating business strategies, both domestic and international.

Business, Government, and Society

All firms operate within competitive and institutional landscapes shaped and framed by the government. Government institutions regulate a broad scope of business activities from the environment, finance, accounting, marketing, human resource management, governance, and mergers and acquisitions. The government funds much of the foundational infrastructure necessary for industry to succeed, including basic research, trade enforcement, transportation, currency, and credit. Yet firms have the power to help shape the role of government through non-market strategy, both to protect their own interests as well as help streamline and improve the efficacy of the public-private partnership.

Furthermore, managers must navigate the complex intersection between business objectives and the values, norms, and expectations of the societies in which they operate. This course will address this challenge through two principal channels. The course will also examine the broader interaction of business and society, including how government, interest groups, employees, and customers interact with the choices made by firms, focusing on issues of sustainability and corporate social responsibility.

This course harnesses Olin's unique partnership with the Brookings Institution to access high-level experts from agencies and institutions in the federal government only accessible in the

capital area. We will focus on how a better understanding of these institutions' mindset, objectives, and operations can help managers better shape strategy and activities at the intersection of the public and private sectors.

Course Expectations

This residency will thrive only with the dedicated preparation and participation of the EMBA students. Given this, I have several crucial expectations for each student during the residency:

1. Prepare the readings in the course pack before heading to D.C.: This preparation is important for classroom discussion and is crucial to get full value out of our expert speakers.
2. Be open to engaging with the speakers, the professor, and each other: As usual, participation is critical. Consider before each day what you would like to learn from or ask of each expert.
3. Use political ideology respectfully. Our program is full of dedicated people from public service, with both Republican and Democratic affiliations. Respect their service, even if you disagree with policies or viewpoints. Frame your questions in ways that promote learning and dialogue.
4. Enjoy D.C.: We want you to be free to spend your evenings enjoying the city. If you prepare your readings before the trip (with good notes), there will be no homework at night. ☺ We don't care how late you're out, so long as you're at class on time in the morning and full of EMBA spirit!

Short Biography

Tarek Ghani is an Assistant Professor of Strategy at Washington University's Olin Business School, where he teaches strategy and business, government & society. He is also a Nonresident Fellow of the Brookings Institution's Global Economy and Development Program and formerly served as Chief Economist of the International Crisis Group. Tarek's academic research explores the private sector's role in – and responses to – crisis and conflict across a range of fragile contexts. He holds a Ph.D. from U.C. Berkeley and a B.S. from Stanford University.

Individual Assignment

What is the largest non-market challenge or opportunity facing your employer (or your business unit or team)? Write a memo that addresses: (1) Why this is a non-market issue? (2) Who are the government and non-government stakeholders, and what are their interests and current actions/positions? And (3) how your employer can better navigate the non-market environment, and how this residency and its speakers has helped inform you on this topic?

- Submission details: 2-3 pages double-spaced, upload to Canvas by 11:59PM Monday, April 21.

Group Assignment

Imagine the month is April 2028. Under the cover of military exercises, China launches an invasion of Taiwan to pursue President Xi Jinping's goal of "reunification" with the island. With the U.S. focused inward – particularly given our presidential election cycle – the attack surprises the world, and it is not immediately clear how the U.S. government will respond. After reviewing the online resources below, discuss in teams how each of your employers might be affected by this type of geopolitical crisis both in the near-term (e.g. 1 year) and medium-term (3-5 years).

Next, agree as a group on **one employer** that you decide is most interesting to focus on and prepare a five-page memo addressing the following questions **for that one employer**:

- (1) What is Taiwan's importance to the U.S. government across political, security and economic domains and what is Taiwan's importance to Chinese government across those same three domains? Are any of these assessments of importance changing over time?
 - (2) Consider three potential U.S. government responses to the invasion: (i) public criticism by the U.S. but no action, (ii) U.S. military aid to Taiwan and economic sanctions on China, or (iii) a U.S. military deployment to defend Taiwan. How likely do you consider each of these potential responses and what analysis or evidence supports this judgement?
 - (3) For each U.S. government response, summarize your views of the most likely market and nonmarket impacts on the **one employer** you chose both in the near-term (e.g. 1 year) or the medium-term (3-5 years). Indicate which impacts you expect to be spread across the economy, shared within this employer's industry, or specific only to this employer.
 - (4) If the employer knew with high certainty (e.g. 90%) today that this would happen in three years, what market and nonmarket actions would you recommend to best prepare for this scenario? How does your answer change if you only had a 10% confidence in this scenario?
- Submission details: 4-5 pages double-spaced, upload to Canvas by 11:59PM Monday, April 28.

Geopolitical expert predictions for the upcoming decade:

<https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/content-series/atlantic-council-strategy-paper-series/welcome-to-2035/>

Political and security context for a Taiwan contingency:

<https://www.cfr.org/task-force-report/us-taiwan-Relations-in-a-new-era/findings>

<https://features.csis.org/preparing-the-US-industrial-base-to-deter-conflict-with-China/>

<https://www.cnas.org/publications/reports/swarms-over-the-strait>

Economic context for a Taiwan contingency:

<https://rhg.com/research/taiwan-economic-disruptions/>

<https://www.csis.org/analysis/silicon-island-assessing-taiwans-importance-us-economic-growth-and-security>

<https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/in-depth-research-reports/report/sanctioning-china-in-a-taiwan-crisis-scenarios-and-risks/>

Tuesday, April 1, 2025

Arrival – Dinner on own

Wednesday, April 2, 2025

8:00 – 8:30 AM

Breakfast

WashU at Brookings

1776 Massachusetts Ave NW

8th Floor Classroom

8:30 – 9:00 AM

Welcome and Course Overview

- Tarek Ghani, Assistant Professor of Strategy, Olin Business School
- Ian Dubin, Associate Dean and Managing Director, WashU at Brookings
- Hillary Rothberg, Program Manager, WashU at Brookings

9:00 – 10:45 AM

Non-Market Strategy: An Introduction

- Tarek Ghani, Assistant Professor of Strategy, Olin Business School

10:45 – 11:00 AM

Break

11:00 AM – 12:00 PM

Business and Government: A Vital Relationship

- Rick Dearborn, Partner, Mindset; former Deputy Chief of Staff to President Donald Trump

12:00 – 1:00 PM

Lunch

1:00 – 2:00 PM

Global Non-Market Strategy

- Tarek Ghani, Assistant Professor of Strategy, Olin Business School

2:00 – 2:15 PM

Break

2:15 – 3:15 PM

Understanding the Federal Budget and Long-Term Debt

- Maya MacGuineas, President, Committee for a Responsible Federal Budget

3:15 – 3:30 PM

Break

3:30 – 4:00 PM

Day 1 in Review

- Tarek Ghani, Assistant Professor of Strategy, Olin Business School

4:00 – 4:30 PM

Capitol Tour and National Mall Logistics

- Hillary Rothberg, Program Manager, WashU at Brookings
- Jenn Michaelree Squire, Program Manager, WashU at Brookings

Wednesday, April 2, 2025 (continued)

- 4:30 PM** **Return to Royal Sonesta**
- 5:00 PM** **Bus Departs Royal Sonesta for Citi Reception**
- 5:30 – 7:00 PM** **A Washington Government Affairs Office Reception**
Citi Rooftop
1101 Pennsylvania Ave NW
- 7:00 PM** **Adjournment**
- Bus returns to Royal Sonesta
 - Dinner on own

Thursday, April 3, 2025

- 7:00 AM** **Bus Departs Royal Sonesta**
*granola bars available on bus
- 7:30 – 9:00 AM** **U.S. Capitol Tour**
- Russ Carnahan, former Congressman, United States House of Representatives (D-MO); Chair, Missouri Democratic Party
- 9:00 – 9:15 AM** **Walk to Capitol Hill Club**
- 9:15 – 9:45 AM** **Breakfast**
Capitol Hill Club
300 First St. SE
Speakers/California Rooms
- 9:45 – 11:00 AM** **The White House and the Regulatory Process**
- Michael Fitzpatrick, Partner, Brunswick Group; former Associate Administrator, Office of Information and Regulatory Affairs, Office of Management and Budget
- 11:00 – 11:15 AM** **Break**
- 11:15 AM – 12:15 PM** **Policy and Society: Crisis Management**
- Tarek Ghani, Assistant Professor of Strategy, Olin Business School
- 12:15 – 1:15 PM** **Lunch**
- 1:15 – 2:15 PM** **Media and Public Policy**
- Major Garrett, Chief Washington Correspondent, CBS News
- 2:15 – 2:30 PM** **Break**

Thursday, April 3, 2025 (continued)

2:30 – 3:30 PM

The Supreme Court

- Jessica Ellsworth, Partner, Litigation, Arbitration, and Employment, Hogan Lovells

3:30 – 4:00 PM

Day 2 in Review and Day 3 Logistics

- Tarek Ghani, Assistant Professor of Strategy, Olin Business School

4:00 PM

Adjournment

- Opportunity to explore independently
- Transport back to hotel available from Capitol Hill Club
 - Bus to stop at National Museum of American History then continues to Royal Sonesta
- Dinner on own

Friday, April 4, 2025

7:30 – 8:00 AM

Breakfast

WashU at Brookings

1776 Massachusetts Ave NW

8th Floor Classroom

8:00 – 10:00 AM

Roundtable Discussions with International Scholars

Small roundtable discussions with scholars and affiliated experts exploring a range of international issues:

- Madiha Afzal, Fellow – Foreign Policy, Center for Middle East Policy, Strobe Talbott Center for Security, Strategy, and Technology, Center for Asia Policy Studies, The Brookings Institution
- Vanda Felbab-Brown, Director – Initiative on Nonstate Armed Actors, Co-Director – Africa Security Initiative, Senior Fellow – Foreign Policy, Strobe Talbott Center for Security, Strategy, and Technology, The Brookings Institution
- Amy Nelson, Visiting Fellow, Future Security Program, New America
- Natan Sachs, Director – Center for Middle East Policy, Senior Fellow – Foreign Policy, Center for Middle East Policy, The Brookings Institution
- Landry Signe, Senior Fellow – Global Economy and Development, Africa Growth Initiative, The Brookings Institution
- Melanie Sisson, Senior Fellow – Foreign Policy, Strobe Talbott Center for Security, Strategy, and Technology, The Brookings Institution

10:00 – 10:15 AM

Break

10:15 – 11:15 AM

American Foreign Policy and Business

- Michael O'Hanlon, Director of Research, Foreign Policy, and Philip H. Knight Chair in Defense and Strategy, The Brookings Institution

Friday, April 4, 2025 (continued)

11:15 – 11:30 AM	Break
11:30 AM – 12:30 PM	U.S. Monetary Policy and the Federal Reserve ▪ Aaron Klein, Miriam K. Carliner Chair and Senior Fellow in Economic Studies, The Brookings Institution
12:30 – 1:30 PM	Lunch
1:30 – 2:30 PM	Tax Policy: What to Expect ▪ Douglas Holtz-Eakin, President, American Action Forum
2:30 – 2:45 PM	Break
2:45 – 3:45 PM	Immigration and U.S. Economic Growth ▪ Alex Nowrasteh, Vice President for Economic and Social Policy Studies, Cato Institute
3:45– 4:00 PM	Break
4:00 – 4:30 PM	Business and Emerging Global Trends ▪ Tarek Ghani, Assistant Professor of Strategy, Olin Business School
4:30 – 4:45 PM	Day 3 in Review ▪ Tarek Ghani, Assistant Professor of Strategy, Olin Business School
4:45 PM	Adjournment and Dinner on own

Saturday, April 5, 2025

The Royal Sonesta

All lectures in the Phillips Ballroom

Starting at 7:00 AM

Store luggage in Hirshhorn room

7:30 – 8:30 AM

Breakfast (in the Freer room)

8:30 – 9:30 AM

China

- Robert Daly, Director, Kissinger Institute on China and The United States, Woodrow Wilson International Center for Scholars

9:30 – 9:45 AM

Break

9:45 – 10:45 AM

International Trade

- Amb. Arturo Sarukhan, former Mexican Ambassador to the United States

10:45 – 11:00 AM

Break

11:00 AM – 12:00 PM

The Environment and Climate Change

- Jeffrey Holmstead, Partner, Bracewell LLP; former Assistant Administrator, United States Environmental Protection Agency

12:00 – 1:00 PM

Lunch (in the Freer room)

1:00 – 2:00 PM

Generative Artificial Intelligence & Work

- Molly Kinder, Fellow – Brookings Metro, The Brookings Institution

2:00 – 2:15 PM

Break

2:15 – 2:45 PM

Business and Society: A Strategic Imperative

- Tarek Ghani, Assistant Professor of Strategy, Olin Business School

2:45 PM

Class Adjournment